

AI FEEDBACK THAT CANNOT COST A GRADE

AI feedback on student writing is arriving in every platform, and **the default way it is built is wrong in three specific ways**. Here are the three rules that fix it.

The three rules, and every one of them is about what the tool may not do.

- 1 · It saves first and speaks second**, so feedback can never block a submission.
- 2 · Its opinion never touches the mark**. Mechanics are excluded from every score.
- 3 · Three things, not everything**. A page of corrections is a verdict, not feedback.

This works whether or not you ever touch AI

All three are about **when feedback arrives and what it is allowed to cost**, and they apply the same to comments you write yourself on a Sunday evening. **If your school has bought an AI writing tool, page 4 is the page you want** — eight questions to ask before it reads a single student's work.

Where this comes from

I teach high school woodshop and I built the reading and assessment software my own classes use. It gives mechanics feedback on written answers. **Every rule here is one I had to write into it**, usually after getting it wrong first.

Inside, in five pages

The three rules, each with what the default build does instead · what the research actually says, **including the caveat usually left out** · **eight questions** to ask an AI writing tool before it reads a word · and a fill-in page that runs one assignment you already give through all three.

RULE 1

It saves first, and speaks second

The student presses submit. **The answer is written down.** Only then does the coach appear. In that order, always, and the order is the whole rule.

What the default build does instead

It reads the work, decides it is not ready, and **holds the submit button hostage until the student fixes what it flagged.** It feels helpful when you demonstrate it. In a real room it means a student who has finished cannot hand in, with four minutes left, because software has an opinion about a comma.

Three things that go wrong when the tool can block

Work gets lost. The student who cannot submit closes the tab. Nothing you say afterward gets that back.

The student starts writing for the tool. Short, safe, mechanically clean sentences get through the gate fastest, so that is what you receive. You have optimized for the checker and taught nothing.

You lose the evidence. The draft the student actually produced is the thing you needed to see. A gate means you only ever see the version that satisfied the gate.

Build it so the wrong thing is impossible, rather than so that you are careful.

You could instead write a rule saying "never let the coach stop a student submitting" and hope everyone remembers it on a wet Tuesday in February. **Saving before the coach runs means nobody has to remember** — there is no moment at which blocking is even available.

If you are not building anything

The same rule in a room with no software: **collect the work first, then talk about it.** Not "let me look before you hand that in." Taking it in is what makes the feedback safe to give, because at that point it cannot cost the student anything.

Its opinion never touches the mark

Mechanics are excluded from every score in my software. The coach can say a sentence is a fragment. It cannot cost a single point for saying so, and the student is told that.

Why this is not softness

A mark is a claim about whether a student understood something. **The moment spelling moves it, the mark is partly a claim about spelling** and you can no longer read it as evidence of understanding. Separating them is not lowering a standard; it is keeping the number meaningful. Mark the mechanics separately if you need to — just not in the same number.

And there is evidence that a comment next to a score does nothing

Ruth Butler's 1988 study put 132 fifth and sixth graders into three conditions: **grades only, comments only, or both**. Interest and performance were generally higher after comments than after grades alone *or grades with comments*. Students who got both **read the score and ignored the comment**.

The caveat, because it is usually left out. The effect held for students in the bottom 25 percent of the class. High achievers who received good grades kept their interest either way. So this is a strong argument about who gets hurt, rather than a universal law — and the students it is about are the ones a writing coach is for.

Three things, not everything

My coach returns **at most three** items on any answer. That cap is in the software, not in my judgment on the day.

Why a cap and not "everything it finds"

A model will happily return nineteen observations about a paragraph. **Nineteen is not nine more useful than three; it is a verdict on the student** and it gets skimmed and closed. Three is roughly what a person acts on. If the same three come back next time, that is the signal — and it is legible precisely because there are only three.

The sentence worth stealing for your own room.

"This is about the writing, and it is not about the grade." **Say it before the feedback, not after.** A student who hears it afterward has already read the comment as a sentence.

Eight questions before it reads student writing

Most teachers will never build this; they will be handed one. **These are the eight questions to ask, and the answers you want.** Ask them of the sales page, then of the tool.

#	Ask	The answer you want
1	Can a student submit while the tool is still unhappy with the work?	Yes, always. If no, stop here.
2	Is the work saved before the feedback runs?	Yes, and it can be shown.
3	Does anything the tool says change a score anywhere?	No. If yes, which scores, and can you switch it off?
4	How many items does it return at once, and can you cap it?	A cap you control, and a small default.
5	Is student writing used to train a model?	No, in writing, in the contract.
6	Who else can read the feedback it gives a student?	You. Not other students, not by default.
7	What happens when the internet drops mid-lesson?	The work is still saved. Feedback can wait.
8	Can you see what it told a student, after the fact?	Yes. You are accountable for it either way.

The one that gets skipped

Question 3 is the one nobody asks, and the answer is often "a little." A tool that quietly folds a mechanics score into a participation or effort number has done exactly the thing rule 2 forbids, and the student never finds out why their number moved.

And the honest one about questions 5 and 6

Student writing is student work, and in most of it a student will eventually mention something about themselves.

Treat anything a child wrote as identifiable, because sooner or later it is. That is the same rule this store applies to every product it sells: **decide by where the data goes and who can reach it,** not by whether a name appears.

Run one thing you already assign through the three rules

Pick one piece of writing you take in regularly — an ordinary one. You are looking for the place where your feedback costs a student something they did not expect to pay.

The assignment

Rule 1 · Does anything have to be fixed before it can be handed in?

A checklist, a tool that will not submit, a "let me see it first." Write what it is, or write *nothing*.

Rule 2 · Does spelling, grammar or neatness move the number?

Including quietly: a rubric row, a rounding, an impression. If it does, write how much. Most people cannot say.

Rule 3 · How many separate things does a student get back?

Count the marks on the last one you handed back, then write the three you would have kept.

The test for whether it worked

Hand the next one back and ask a student what they will do differently. If they tell you the score instead, it did not land — and rule 2 is where to look first.

If you would rather the rule lived in software than in your memory

Our AI professional development staff trainings are ready-to-run sessions with the full script, for the conversation a staff has to have before a tool like this is bought rather than after. Search our store.

If this was useful, would you leave a review?

TPT gives you credit toward future purchases, and reviews decide whether another teacher ever sees this. Page 3 source: Butler, 1988.